

Workplace Culture and Connection 2026

Make culture thrive by fostering communication, camaraderie, and trust at all levels of the organization.



Organizations need to work on culture and connection

CONNECTION IS THE FOUNDATION OF WORKPLACE CULTURE AND ONE OF THE STRONGEST REASONS PEOPLE STAY



of employees say they remain with an organization primarily because of **culture and the people they work with**



say they feel a **sense of belonging** at their organization

However, many organizations continue to face challenges

20% hesitate to recommend their organization as a great place to work

1 in 5 report their sense of connection declined over the past year

48% report moderate or low trust in leadership

On the surface, things look good, but connection across the organization is also uneven.



86%

feel connected to their immediate team



58%

say the organization fosters relationships beyond those teams

So how can organizations improve workplace culture and connection?

01 First, determine your biggest culture and connection obstacles

Cultural strain rarely shows up as a single issue. It accumulates through everyday experiences.

When determining the biggest culture and connection obstacles, employees most often point to:

- 1

lack of clear communication and transparency
- 2

not feeling recognized or valued
- 3

change fatigue and declining morale

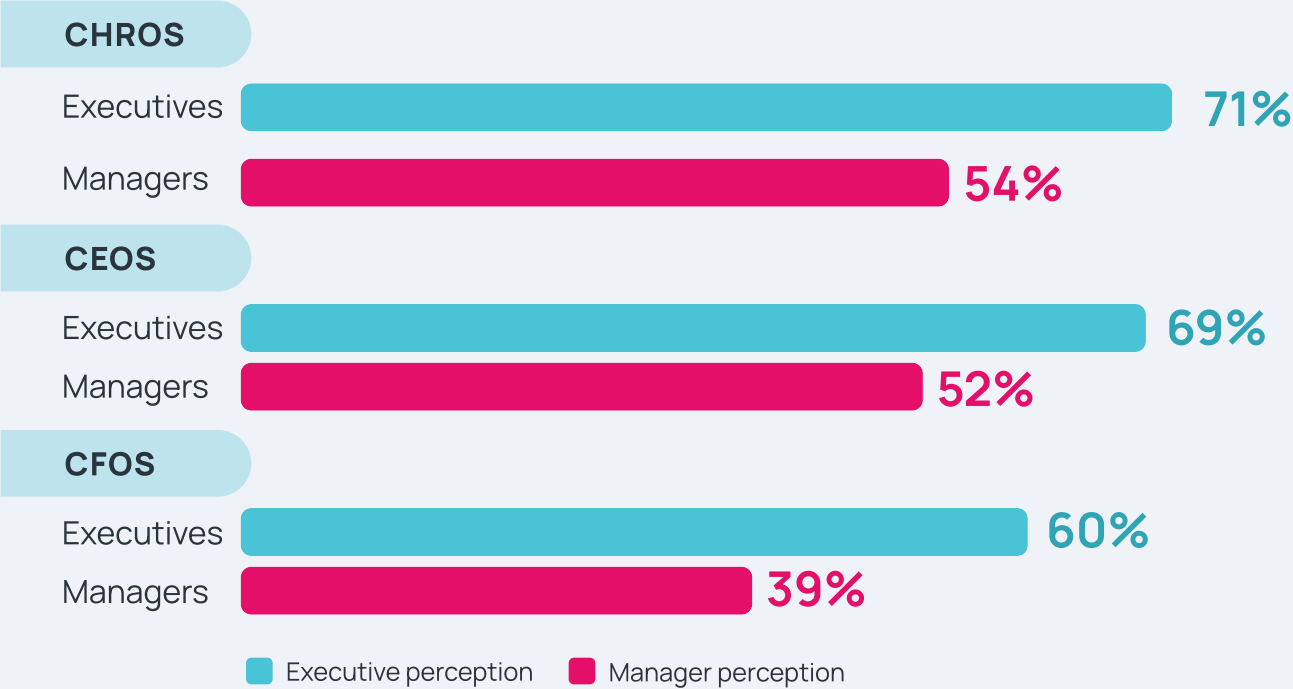


02 Second, show that leadership cares

When leadership connection is visible, trust grows. When it is not, even well-intentioned culture efforts lose credibility.

There is a disconnect in perception of top leadership involvement.

Executives are much more likely than managers to believe the C-suite is involved in improving the work environment to a high or very high degree:



MOREOVER

16%

of employees and managers trust leadership to a very high extent

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Compared to culture laggard organizations*, culture leader organizations** are:

8X more likely to report high trust in leadership (83% vs. 10%)

3X+ more likely to say the CHRO takes an active role in improving the work environment (70% vs.22%)

****Culture leaders:** Organizations where employees responded with a rating of 8 to 10, when asked how likely they would be to recommend their organization as a great place to work.

***Culture laggards:** Organizations where employees responded with a rating of 0 to 6 to the same question.

03 Third, ensure you’re using tools to build relationships and skills

1/3 of organizations aren’t measuring employee engagement, making it difficult to overcome culture & connection challenges.

And most aren’t using the following resources to help build relationships:



% of organizations NOT offering these tools to build relationships

Not to mention,

59%

of managers and executives do not know their organization’s Employee Net Promoter Score (eNPS)

54%

do not know voluntary turnover rates

Without this visibility, it is difficult to understand whether employees feel connected, valued, or willing to advocate for the organization.



04 Fourth, reinforce connection through consistent recognition

Recognition is one of the most direct ways employees experience connection, yet it’s inconsistent across many organizations.

37%

of employees rarely or never receive meaningful recognition from their **direct manager**

35%

rarely or never receive meaningful recognition from **peers**

Compared to employees in culture laggard organizations, those in culture leader organizations are:

16X

more likely to receive weekly or daily recognition from managers **(94% vs. 6%)**

9X

more likely to receive frequent peer recognition **(95% vs. 10%)**



Final key takeaway

Connection is not just a nice-to-have. It is how culture produces trust, engagement, and results. Organizations that track connection, recognize it when it happens, and show visible leadership consistently perform better than those that don't.

When you treat connection like a system rather than a feeling, culture becomes something you can build on, not something you just hope holds together.



The State of Workplace Culture and Connection 2026

Read Full Report



About the Survey:

The HR Research Institute (HRI) fielded "The State of Workplace Culture and Connection 2025-26" survey in October 2025 in collaboration with Motivosity. We gathered 5,538 total responses from participants located worldwide, though predominantly from North America. Participants span diverse industries, with 80% representing midsize or large organizations.

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